

Growing Up With a Twelve-Year-Old Jesus

Luke 2:41-52

Every year Jesus' parents went to Jerusalem for the Festival of the Passover. When he was twelve years old, they went up to the festival, according to the custom. After the festival was over, while his parents were returning home, the boy Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem, but they were unaware of it. Thinking he was in their company, they traveled on for a day. Then they began looking for him among their relatives and friends. When they did not find him, they went back to Jerusalem to look for him. After three days they found him in the temple courts, sitting among the teachers, listening to them and asking them questions. Everyone who heard him was amazed at his understanding and his answers. When his parents saw him, they were astonished. His mother said to him, "Son, why have you treated us like this? Your father and I have been anxiously searching for you." "Why were you searching for me?" he asked. "Didn't you know I had to be in my Father's house?" But they did not understand what he was saying to them. Then he went down to Nazareth with them and was obedient to them. But his mother treasured all these things in her heart. And Jesus grew in wisdom and stature, and in favor with God and man.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Have you ever been separated from your parents? It isn't very fun to look up, look around, and suddenly realize that you can't see them anywhere. Maybe you wandered away from Mom at the store because you wanted to look at the toys. Or Mom and Dad were so focused on something else that they thought you were right there with them. It doesn't matter how it happened, but getting lost isn't a great feeling. For you or your parents.

Jesus was twelve years old when he got separated from his family in the big city of Jerusalem at Passover. You'd probably feel more than just lost and a little scared in a strange city, right? But when Mary and Joseph finally found him three days later, Jesus was calm and confident. He wasn't wandering around or getting into trouble. He was in the temple (God's house), listening and asking questions about God.

Jesus was so special. While other twelve-year-olds might have been distracted or focused on other things, Jesus was perfect—completely focused on honoring God. He loved learning about God's Word and amazed everyone around him with his wisdom. Jesus was showing us what it looks like to love God with all our heart, soul, and mind.

But here's the amazing part: Jesus wasn't just an example to follow. He was also our perfect substitute. As a 12-year-old child, a teenager, and an adult, Jesus lived every day perfectly on our behalf. When he asked questions in the temple, listened closely, and amazed the teachers, he was perfectly fulfilling God's law for us. Jesus did everything right so that he could offer his perfect life for us, even starting as a young boy.

Knowing this gives us peace. God doesn't love us because we're perfect students or because we always focus on what's right. He loves us because Jesus did all of that for us. So, as we learn and grow, just like Jesus did, we don't have to worry about being perfect. Instead, we can follow his example, knowing that he has already done everything perfectly for us.

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- If Jesus was here right now, what questions would you like to ask him?
- Instead of scared and lost, how do you think Jesus felt when he was in the temple, learning about God?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Jesus loved learning God's Word! When do you find yourself most interested in learning God's Word?
- Why do you think Jesus wanted to stay in the temple, even though his parents were on their way home?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- A twelve-year-old Jesus was willing to spend time learning, asking questions, and growing in his understanding. How does his example as a preteen help you in your own faith?
- Name one way you can heighten your desire for God's Word even when other things in life feel more exciting or important.

Closing Prayer:

Jesus, thank you for reminding us that you once were a child like us. As God's Son, thank you for doing what we should do but couldn't and for doing all of that perfectly in our place. Help us to honor our Father in heaven the same way you did by loving and respecting time spent in his Word and learning more about him. Amen.